

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pentecost 3
Another Kind of Freedom ~
Renewed Strength

21 June 2026



"With the Rainbow"
by artist Paul Klee, 1917

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on BEACH SPRING and LYONS

Four Short Preludes and Fugues (ascribed to Bach):

Prelude and Fugue in C, BWV 553

Prelude and Fugue in d, BWV 554

Prelude and Fugue in e, BWV 555

Prelude and Fugue in F, BWV 556

Oblivion (Astor Piazzolla)

Dr. Stephen Caplan, Oboe
Dr. Christoph Bull, Organ

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

The abiding love of God cradles the entire cosmos.

All of eternity rests in the embrace of Sacred Wisdom.

When our fears and limitations crowd our perception of what is possible
we remember, our help comes from God.

In memory of the ancestors who leaned on strength, courage, and wisdom
in the most trying of times and in solidarity with all who dare
to practice hope in these days,
let us gather with the presence of the Holy One, that we might be renewed
in this sacred time and place.

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

O Spirit of Power

LYONS

O Spirit of Power, who dwells in us all,
Inspire us each hour to follow your call.
Awaken our vision to all we can be,
And challenge our labor to set people free.

Though many your names, Love reigns over all;
With you we can claim our life-giving call.
Cast out all our fear so with you we can soar,
Creating a world never dreamed of before.

O Spirit of Love, compassionate Friend,
Within and above, your strength knows no end.
Your rivers of healing revive thirsty land;
All goodness and nourishment flow from your hand.

O Spirit of Power, O Love beyond thought,
Our gifts with you flower; what wonders are wrought.
Creator, Redeemer, and Comforting Guide,
Illumine our lives as with you we abide.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

Holy One of Many Names, in your strength all things are in motion.
Where change is needed in our thinking or our beliefs,
in our practices or our ways of relating to each other,
be our guide.

*Give us courage to stay present to that,
which makes us uncomfortable.
Give us patience when we are unsettled.
Give us strength when we face loss.
Give us the faith to welcome necessary change,
eagerly or tepidly, for the sake of your dream for our world.*

On this day that has never been before - remind us, O God,
that your Spirit is always and forever
bringing new possibilities to light.
Help us to be open to her wisdom
as she speaks into our reality,
giving us eyes to see things as they are,
so that we can bring courage to our beloved world-
and embrace its new realities.

May it be so.
*May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

"Strength, Courage, and Wisdom"
Cathedral Choir, Molly Pease, *Soloist*

INDIA ARIE, arr. MOLLY PEASE

***The Lord's Prayer**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

*Holy One, beyond all names,
Eternal Wellspring,
May love rise again in us today
with food for every table,
shelter for every family,
and reverence for every life.*

*Forgive us our failings in love
and free us from all falseness,
that the light of our souls may shine,
and the strength of our spirits endure
for Earth and all its people
This day, tonight, and forever.*

-John Philip Newell

Amen and Amen!

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

Each week as we gather, we sense the presence
of the Spirit of Life and Hope,
in this sacred time.

On this day, together we are being awakened once again
to the mysteries that humble us,
the realities that orient us,
and the community that sustains us -
in order that we may give ourselves in honesty and openness
to the expanding life before us.

As we commit to becoming a blessing
to the people and places we love...

May the Peace of God be with you,
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from Isaiah 40

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

For this witness of the ancestors,
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

*After the silence, you are invited to come forward to bring your written prayers
and to light candles to signify the prayers of your hearts and pray for the life of the world.*

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

God of hope and vision,
you have called us to invest our lives
in new possibilities, in dreams we cannot imagine
but that reside within the restlessness
of your Holy Spirit.

You have imagined
a night without fear, an eternal season
without drought without hunger without war without hate;
we have lamented and longed for these!
Now show us the way.
Time and time again
you have taught us to love one another
and to work for the relief of oppression, isolation, and poverty;
the lesson has been learned;
now stir within us the courage to act.

*We pray on this day for those who are grieving,
those who are longing for home;
those who are sick and suffering; those who are outcast.
We reach out in love to all people and creation...
as you, O God, reach out to us.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Meditation Anthem

"The Peace of Wild Things"
Laude, Stephen Caplan, Oboe

MICHAEL CONLEY

"When despair for the world grows in me and I wake in the night at the least sound in fear of what my life and my children's lives may be, I go and lie down where the wood drake rests in his beauty on the water, and the great heron feeds. I come into the peace of wild things who do not tax their lives with forethought of grief. I come into the presence of still water. And I feel above me the day-blind stars waiting with their light. For a time I rest in the grace of the world, and am free." ~Wendell Berry

Sermon

Renewed Strength

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Invitation to Generosity

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Who we are and who we are becoming as individuals,
shows God's presence in the world.
That divine presence is reflected even more fully,
powerfully, and transformatively as we come together
each week in community.

In gratitude for all that is and all that will be,
let us give ourselves, our gifts, and our resources together
so that the expansive love of God may be made real
in this, our time and place.

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Domine Deus" from Gloria
Anna Caplan, *Soloist*, Stephen Caplan, *Oboe*, and Christoph Bull, *Organ*

ANTONIO VIVALDI

"Loving God, Lamb of God who is beloved."

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Dr. Jay Prewitt-Cruz

Faithful God, we thank you that when we journey with you
on this path of faith, we do not journey alone.

We thank you for all those who have, through the centuries,
walked this way before us,
acting in courage and seeking your ways.

We thank you for all those who travel with us today,
helping us to be for each other, your hope and strength.

*Renew our wisdom and courage for the living of these days,
through the grace and goodness of your Divine Presence,
both this day and in all the days to come. Amen and Amen.*

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

As we leave this place,
let us remember
we are the way we got here -
and we are the future now.

So together we say...
We are the moments we have yet to walk into.
We are every dream that's yet to be.
We are the possibilities that can still happen.
We're promises that we will keep.
We are the courage we'll need tomorrow.

We are the power yet to be claimed.
We are the freedom that we can offer.
We are chances we have yet to take.
We are the way we will get there.
We are the future now.

May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Choral Response “The Lord Is My Shepherd” (excerpt) from *Requiem* JOHN RUTTER
Cathedral Choir, Stephen Caplan, Oboe

***Hymn for the Journey** “*The Journey of Faith*” BEACH SPRING
To a journey God has called us, to a life of love and hope;
In the light and in the shadow, God is with us as we go.
Faith that grows with each new challenge, trust that leads through paths unknown,
We, as pilgrims, walk together in the journey to our home.

For the strength of faithful witness lived through days of joy and tears;
And the gift of grace sufficient for the ever-flowing year;
For the richness of your mercy to thee, Lord, we give you our praise.
May our lives reflect your glory ‘till the close of all our days.

Go we now to be God’s people, go we now our faith to live.
Help us learn from one another faith to keep, a faith to give.
Go we now on life’s great journey, go we now, but not alone.
With God’s people, by God’s Spirit, faith leads forward, faith leads on.

Postlude **Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence**
Short Prelude in F - Reprise (ascribed to Bach) and Improvisation

Inside The Music **Dr. David Harris**

“We are so pleased to have renowned oboist and Anna’s father, Stephen Caplan, with us this week. The oboe has been a favorite obbligato instrument of vocal composers for centuries. Baroque composers frequently paired oboe and soprano. Stephen and Anna will bring us the “Domine Deus” from Vivaldi’s “Gloria,” for example. The timbral qualities of the oboe combine with the treble classical timbre in exciting, clarifying ways that exude an almost otherworldly quality. In this moment of the text, Vivaldi chooses to apply that other worldiness to a recognition of Jesus’ connection to the divine strength of the Creator. John Rutter’s “Requiem” became a staple in the choral repertoire almost overnight. His use of the oboe in his distinctly pastorate setting of the 23rd Psalm is the centerpiece of its success. The solo oboe has a history of referencing pastoral, natural beauty. Rutter’s oboe line immediately calms and transports us from the torpor of worry into the delights of connection to the divine. A more recent composition by my dear friend Michael Conley comes from his “Appalachian Requiem.” Here, too, Michael uses the oboe to draw us into the natural world. Unlike Rutter’s paragon of peacefulness, though, Michael’s oboe part communes with the choir in the poem’s narrative development. Berry’s “The Peace of Wild Things” mirrors the 23rd Psalm in its recognition of worry, and release into the divine through nature. Michael’s music brings us into those worried places. The music’s sustained energy during the first half of the piece keeps us stuck, unable to move from the things that weigh us down. The oboe leads the way in creating that energy. It also provides the musical ideas that will eventually free us from these stuck places. As the choir spins on itself, the oboe quietly echoes and then

releases into florid lines. In time the choir frees itself and joins the oboe in recognition that release is possible. As they settle into a new peacefulness, the oboe again returns to its florid lines, the song of nature heard as if for the first time. These pieces remind us that strength in the face of struggle begins by seeking connections outside of us. As we lean into our awareness gifts, we find the grandeur of creation awaiting us with its connecting power.”

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